# OCEANIC EMPIRES



**Battle of Gibraltar**
After the Dutch had gained the upper hand in their own home waters, they extended their naval operations to attack Spanish shipping in its overseas colonies and even off the coast of Spain, as here at Gibraltar in 1607, where they destroyed an entire Spanish fleet of 21 ships.

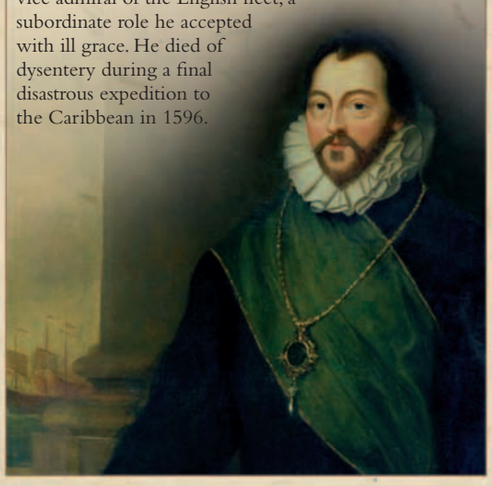
**THE OCEANIC VOYAGES** of European sailors wrought fundamental changes in world trade and power politics in the 16th century. The Portuguese played a leading part in the initial voyages of exploration, establishing bases in Africa, Brazil, and India, and reaching as far as Japan by the 1540s. Trade in Asian spices and other luxury goods brought wealth flooding into the coffers of the Portuguese monarchy. But it was Spain that emerged as the first oceanic imperial power. After backing Christopher Columbus's transatlantic voyage of 1492, the Spanish took control of areas of Central and South America rich in precious metals. Silver from mines in Peru, carried across the Atlantic by an annual treasure fleet, financed a bid by the Spanish monarchy to achieve dominance in Europe. Resistance to Spanish power bred wars in which Dutch and English sailors proved themselves doughty sea fighters against the odds.

c.1540–1596

## SIR FRANCIS DRAKE

**ENGLISH PRIVATEER AND NAVAL COMMANDER**

Born in Tiverton, Devon, England, Francis Drake went to sea at an early age. Fearless, arrogant, and quarrelsome, he built a reputation as a peerless privateer, ravaging the Spanish colonies around the Caribbean. In 1577, with the covert backing of Elizabeth I, he sailed around Cape Horn to attack Spain's possessions on the Pacific coast of the Americas. Returning home in 1580 he was knighted as the first Englishman to circumnavigate the globe. His raid on Cadiz in 1587 confirmed his status as Spain's "most wanted" enemy. During the resistance to the Spanish Armada the following year Drake was vice admiral of the English fleet, a subordinate role he accepted with ill grace. He died of dysentery during a final disastrous expedition to the Caribbean in 1596.



## SPANISH ASCENDANCY

Spain was unquestionably the strongest European naval power in the second half of the 16th century, especially after it annexed Portugal in 1580. Despite having simultaneously to maintain a Mediterranean galley fleet to fight the Ottomans, the Spanish monarchy had the resources and the bureaucratic organization to build and supply a fleet of sail on a scale beyond the reach of any other European state. The Dutch, in revolt against Spanish rule, and the English, determined to remain free of it, had relatively puny resources. What they did possess, however, was a large number of adventurous, independent-minded seamen. The foundations of a permanent English Royal Navy were laid under Henry VIII (reigned 1509–47) and the later Tudors, especially Elizabeth I (reigned 1558–1603), maintained a royal interest in the navy that, by contrast, was only intermittently present in France. But even the English were far from achieving the level of naval organization and funding present in Spain—England typically could not afford to pay the sailors who fought off the Spanish Armada in 1588. Both the Dutch and English depended to a large degree on privateers to wage war upon the Spanish Empire. Men such as Francis Drake and Piet Heyn operated sometimes as licensed pirates or maritime guerrilla fighters, sometimes as conventional naval commanders.



**Heart of the empire**
This view of Cadiz shows Spanish ships preparing to sail to the West Indies. Despite raids by the English and Dutch at the end of the 16th century, Cadiz and Seville remained immensely wealthy commercial centers.

## GUNS AND GALLEONS

During the second half of the 16th century the galleon replaced the carrack as the purpose-built warship in European fleets. A leaner, sleeker vessel, it was built for speed, especially in the low-hulled version favored by the English. How best to use these ships in combat was still a matter for experiment. The English, who had the best cannon, favored gun duels, chiefly targeting the opponent's hull. The Spanish, although fully aware of the importance of guns in naval warfare, regarded cannon fire as a prelude to boarding—their galleons carried large numbers of soldiers. The English, in their smaller, nimbler ships, hoped to avoid being boarded by holding the weather gage and thus dictating the range at which the encounter was fought. The battles of the Spanish Armada campaign showed that English guns were not powerful enough to inflict serious damage upon large Spanish galleons. It is worth noting that the Dutch, using even smaller ships than the English, favored boarding as a tactic.